

Rescue pays off for bird lover

By Bo Petersen
Gazette Staff Reporter

GASTONIA — Ed Barker freed his hawk Friday in a field near the road where he found her two years ago.

He had been warned the red-tailed hawk was frisky. But when the hood came off, she perched a moment on his arm before she pulled back her wings and flew.

That's how he remembers her.

"When I walked into the vet's with that big bird sitting on my arm like a parakeet, those people scattered," Barker said. "The vet came out with a rubber apron, welder's gloves and a catcher's mask."

Barker first saw the bird in January 1990 on the yellow line in the middle of Union Road near South Forty Farm.

He was driving home from work. The hawk, diving for prey, had gotten caught in the radio aerial of a state trooper's car.

"She was lying on her back with her wings spread and her feet in the air," he said. "The bird looked dazed."

She bled from a broken beak. Her right wing bled. Barker told the trooper he would take her home to his chicken coops to recover.

"I just like those big birds," Barker said. "I've got a big old eagle tattooed on my arm."

But when he let go of her talons in the front seat of the Gran Prix, the bird stood and spread her four-foot wings.



Craig Bell/The Gazette

Ed Barker prepares to release a hawk he rescued from a road.

"I said, 'Lord, help me.' It was the loudest I ever prayed. I held the steering wheel with my knee as I got her back down," Barker said.

The bird went instead to a veterinarian, who contacted the Carolina Raptor Center in Huntersville. It's not legal to keep a bird of prey without a permit.

The center is a non-profit rehabilitation and research center for raptors, or birds of prey. In 1991, the center took in 512 injured raptors, including 130 red-tailed hawks.

Nearly half the birds taken in eventually are released into the wild. The

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red-tailed hawk is a commonly seen raptor in the Carolinas.

Barker's hawk recovered quickly in a rehabilitation cage but hurt herself after being moved to a "flight" cage where there is room for the birds to use their wings.

She went back and forth between cages several times.

"She didn't want to fly. It may have been the wing tip was very tender for her," said Betty O'Leary, rehab assistant.

Meanwhile the bird who quietly had perched on Barker's arm became more unruly.

Center staff named her Gret-

chen because it fit her personality, Ms. O'Leary said.

Barker visited the bird often at first but less often as he became convinced she wouldn't get released. He was surprised when the center called him this week saying the bird was ready.

"It made me feel like I did something that should have been done," Barker said.

He nodded to hear the hawk was named Gretchen.

"I used to have a girlfriend named Gretchen," he said.

But Friday morning, the frisky hawk again sat calmly on Barker's arm as he smiled. Then she leaped and flew.

"Now, she's home," Barker said.